SYNTHETIC DEMO POLICY — NOT A REAL HEALTH PLAN POLICY

Medical Policy: MRI lumbar spine — Coverage criteria

Policy number: RHP-IMG-014 Version: 3.2
Effective date: 2026-07-01 Applies to: Regional Health Plan (all lines)
CPT codes: 72148 (without contrast)

1. Purpose

Defines when outpatient MRI of the lumbar spine is medically necessary for members.

2. Covered when ONE of the following is documented

A. Low back pain or radicular symptoms lasting 6 weeks or more AND failure of at least 6 weeks of conservative therapy (physical therapy, and/or NSAIDs or other medication), with documentation of the dates and response.

B. A red flag is present (conservative therapy not required):
- suspected cauda equina syndrome (saddle numbness, new bowel or bladder change)
- history of cancer, or unexplained weight loss
- suspected infection (fever, IV drug use, immunosuppression)
- suspected fracture (significant trauma, osteoporosis, long-term steroid use)
- progressive or severe neurological deficit

C. Planning for surgery or an epidural steroid injection after failed conservative care.

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Medical Policy: MRI lumbar spine — Documentation and exclusions

3. Required documentation

- Clinical note with history, duration of symptoms and neurological exam
- Records of conservative therapy (PT notes or medication history with dates)
- Any red flag findings

4. Not medically necessary

- Acute low back pain under 6 weeks without red flags
- Imaging requested for reassurance only

5. Review

A nurse reviewer applies these criteria. Requests that do not meet them are referred to a medical director. Only a medical director may issue an adverse determination.

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